

Session 31: Submit to One Another

Key Takeaways

- Verse 22 to the wives and verse 25 to the husbands are illustrations of the same governing verb "submitting." Wives and husbands are to submit to one another out of reverence for the Messiah.
- Paul's redefinition of submission as considering other people as more important than yourself was a radical statement in an honor/shame society.

"Mutual Submission" in the Context of the Greco-Roman World: Two Views of Paul's Meaning

View 1

"The pronoun 'to one another' does not mean that all believers are to submit to all other believers but that, among believers, submission should take place as it is described in [5:22-6:9](#)."

Thielman, Frank (2010). [Ephesians \(Baker Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament\)](#). Baker Academic. 373.

View 2

"The mutual submission admonished here relativizes conventional authority structures for people who lived in a society where status and authority were rigidly marked and strictly observed. The epistle's call for a relativity of authority within the Spirit-filled body requires a disposition of humility similar to that described in [Philippians 2:3-4](#), where others are considered to be of higher status, and people attend to the interests of others rather than their own. Moreover, mutual submission is done 'in reverence for Christ.' That is, believers' obedience to Christ will lead them to submit to one another. Whatever authority and status an individual might have in the world is relativized by believers' common service to one Lord, Christ. In this common service they are both able to and called to submit to each other."

Fowl, Stephen E. (2012). [Ephesians: A Commentary](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 186-187.

In view 2, [Ephesians 5:21](#) is parallel to [Galatians 5:13](#) "become slaves of one another through love. ... This expression [Gal. 5:13] adjusts an inherently hierarchical relationship (slavery) not by canceling it, in the name of 'equality,' but by making it reciprocal, a hierarchy that turns both ways. The simple but powerful word 'one another' (Grk. ἀλλήλοις) turns a one-way relationship of power and superiority into a mutual relationship of reciprocal deference, where each seeks to promote the interests of the other."

Barclay, John M. G. (2017). [Paul and the Gift](#). Eerdmans. 435.

Reflection Question

This session presents two views of the concept of mutual submission in the context of the Greco-Roman world. Which view is the most compelling to you and why?